



CAMPAIGN TRAIL Home minister Amit Shah leads a roadshow, Kolkata, Apr. 2; (left) TMC's Abhishek Banerjee at a rally, Harishchandrapur, Apr. 6

HINDUSTAN TIMES

THE PURGE

How the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls played out in Bengal

Electors before SIR
76,637,529

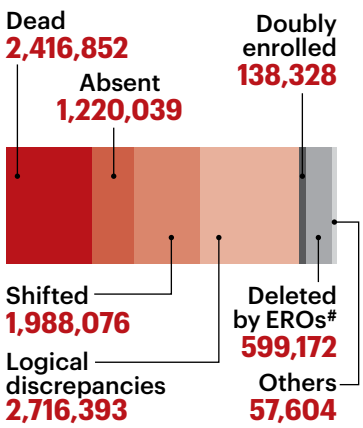
Deletions
9,136,464

New additions*
749,945

Electors after SIR
68,251,010

Reduction in electors
10.9%

THE DELETION CATEGORIES



**Electors included through Form 6 and Form 8*
#Deleted by electoral registration officers based on Form 7 filled in during regular claims and objections by electors themselves or objectors from within the constituency

The BJP Game Plan

For the BJP, Bengal remains unfinished business. The birthplace of its progenitor Syama Prasad Mookerjee, the state remains part of the party's broader ideological project of a Bengali Hindu homeland that must be saved from becoming a Bangladesh. In pursuit of that ideal, the party has undertaken extensive restructuring under Sunil Bansal. More than 700 personnel from outside Bengal have been deployed to oversee electoral operations, including one for each constituency and one for each organisational district, all reporting to state in-charge Bhupender Yadav.

Moreover, all 294 constituencies have been broken into clusters. Data from the 2021 assembly election as well as the 2019 and 2024 general elections have been analysed boothwise. Based on this information, the party has reached the conclusion that elections in Bengal are decided at the margins and the outreach therefore must be at the micro level. BJP footsoldiers have been visiting the homes of sympathisers, especially those they believe have voted the BJP in some election or the other, or booths where the BJP's vote share has seen a surge.

Meanwhile, the Sangh brigade had started its work even before the election was announced—holding some 100,000 micro meetings, talking about the BJP's welfare schemes, law and order issues, especially the 'Abhaya' case (her mother, incidentally, is contesting from Panihati in North 24 Parganas on a BJP ticket). A typical booth, according to BJP calculations, sees on average 150-300 voters. Union home minister Amit Shah has directed that 10-15 voters be added per booth. This will yield 2,500-3,000 additional votes in a constituency of 250-300 booths, enough to flip most close contests.

At a broader level, the party is also working at a region-wise electoral strategy. Every region is monitored by one Union minister and a veteran organisation man (typically loaned from the Sangh). North Bengal remains the party's strongest zone, fetching it 7 out of 8 Lok Sabha seats in 2019 and 30-plus assembly seats in 2021. The campaign this time focuses on the Rajbongshi demand for ST status and recognition of the Koch-Rajbongshi language, distress in the tea gardens that is estimated to affect almost a million workers, and border security. The BJP needs a 2 per cent swing to take its local tally to 35-40 seats. The margins are tighter in Jangalmahal. The BJP won 16 seats here in 2021, many by under 5,000 votes. The BJP